groups, wondering what would happen next, until a photographer arrived and asked us to line up so he could click a photograph. As soon as he had finished, an instructor of the rank of wing commander arrived, along with a bunch of aircraftmen. A very short, crisp introductory speech was delivered by him, followed by certain instructions on general dos and don'ts. Squadrons and academy numbers were allotted to each cadet, soon after the aircraftmen finished checking everyone's luggage to ensure nobody was carrying unauthorized items such as eatables, medicines or cameras. I was allotted to the Brar Squadron and my academy number was 182860.

'You may all go to your squadrons now, keep your luggage, change into whites and come back to fall in at this same place in thirty minutes. Your time here starts now, so does your training,' he said with an air of command. But he was clearly not impressed with the lethargic reaction of everyone present, as they slowly turned around and walked towards the squadrons. He shouted, 'Did you not listen when I said you weren't authorized to walk? You are first-termers and you should be seen doubling up . . . always. Starting from NOW!'

All of a sudden, every girl was on the double, including me. The realization that training had already begun was overwhelming. Running with the luggage took a toll on me and I started to pant. Little did I know I'd be running with more weight on my back very soon. I landed up outside Brar Squadron, along with five other female cadets, helping each other get our luggage to the first floor. My room was second from the last on the right flank. This was when I realized I was on my own from now. The thought was quite frightening. I did not know if I was even prepared to face what was about to come my way.

'Do you have an extra white shirt?' a girl asked as she peeped through the half-open door of my cabin while I was hurriedly unpacking.

'Yes, I think I do.' I took out a shirt and turned to look at the girl. She looked bigger and taller than me. 'But . . . I don't think this will fit you,' I added.

'It's okay. I'll manage,' she said with a smile as she took the shirt from me hurriedly.